

drugs do not have any smell, taste or colour, and are thus difficult to detect. On June 3, a woman was found drugged and assaulted at a luxury hotel in Delhi. Last year, a Delhi-based student in Class XII went through a similar experience with a friend she had met online, who taped the assault and blackmailed her. More recently, Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader Sonali Phogat, who was found murdered in Goa last month, is said to have been surreptitiously drugged by a few male companions.

Dr I.R. Rajkumar, medical director of Alpha Healing Centre in Vadodara, says that cases involving the use of date rape drugs are coming up more often today. Easily accessible through friends or at parties, he adds, "GHB, Ketamine, roofies are common 'party drugs' and you can easily buy them at clubs. They are cheaper than cocaine or heroin."

It must be noted, however, that date rape drugs may also be classified as anything that renders a victim vulnerable to assault—alcohol, over-the-counter treatments such as cold medicine, etc.

GETTING REAL ABOUT ROOFIES

Data on the use of date rape drugs is sparse. A study published in 2020 in the *European Journal of Molecular & Clinical Medicine* states that about 70 per cent of reported sexual assault cases in India are committed while the accused or the victim—or both—are intoxicated. But the number of victims who report date rape definitively is far smaller than those who speak about other forms of sexual assault. While it's possible that the use of date rape drugs is not very widespread yet in India, there are three key reasons for fewer people opening up about being 'roofied': fear of blame, a severe breach of trust in others, and, most importantly, lack of memory of the incident, which is both a common effect of, and one of the reasons for, the use of date rape drugs. "If you are raped by someone you know, trust becomes a critical issue. Forget confiding in a counsellor, many of my patients haven't spoken to even friends and family about